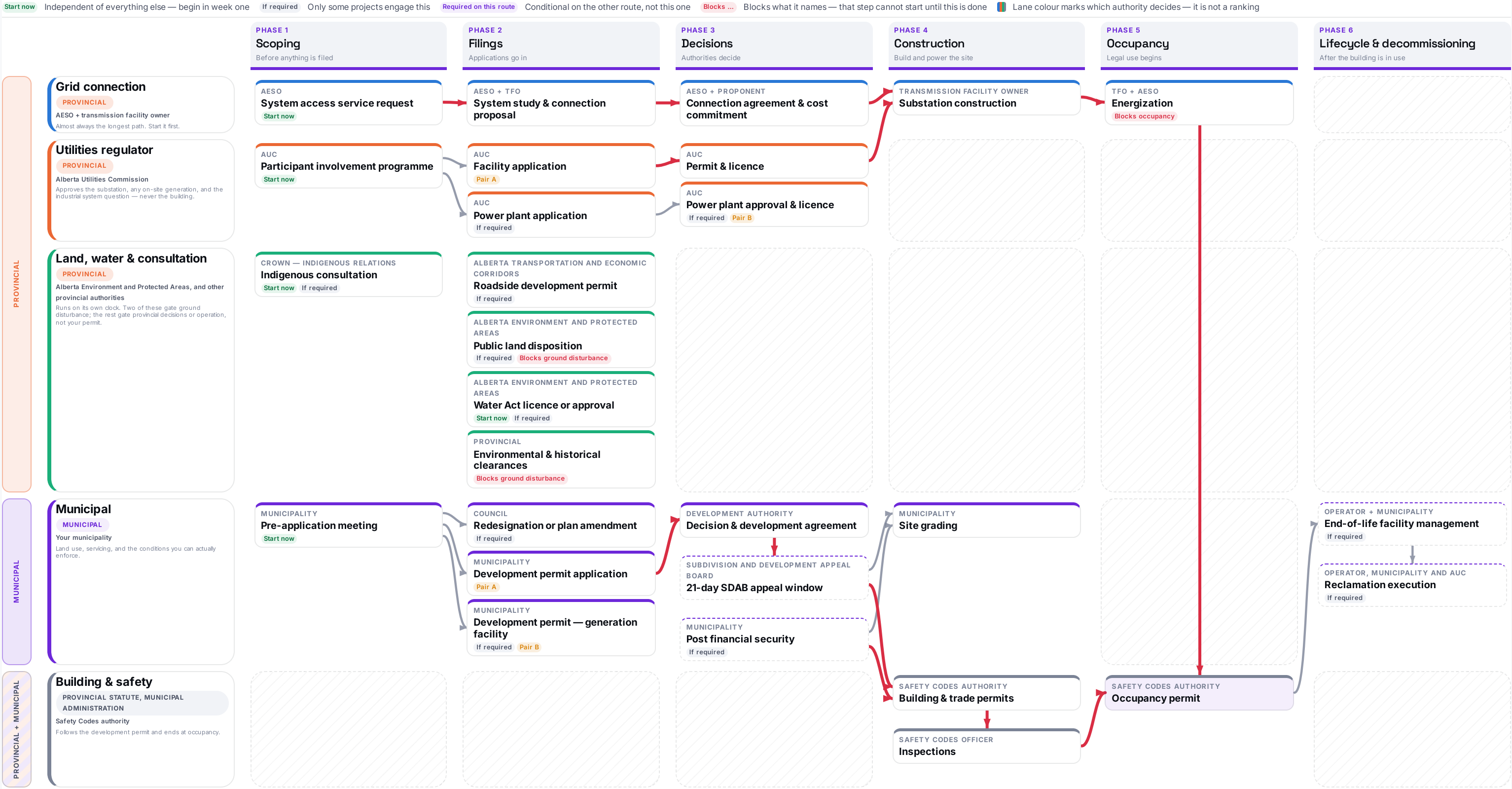


From first enquiry to occupancy

A data centre needs approvals from four different authorities on four different clocks. Most can run in parallel — and must, because the grid connection is almost always the long pole. This shows the whole path, what blocks what, and where each process is actually started.

Load served from the AESO transmission system through a substation built by the transmission facility owner.

Critical path — delay here moves the finish date
Arrow: must finish before
Same column: same stage, no order implied between them
A The same letter on two cards: one thing, two applications — both required, neither authorises the other





The grid is the critical path

Every other approval can usually be obtained faster than a transmission connection. If the AESO request has not been made, the project timeline in the application is unsupported — regardless of how advanced the design is.



The grid track does not stop at the study

The system study is the middle of the grid path, not the end of it. What follows is the connection agreement and cost commitment, the AUC’s decision on the substation, construction by the transmission facility owner, and finally energization — which is what occupancy should be conditioned on.



Four things should start in week one

The AESO request, the municipal pre-application, any water licence, and the AUC participant involvement programme are all independent of each other. Running them in sequence rather than in parallel adds months for no reason.



How to read a pair letter

Two cards carrying the same letter are two separate applications, to two different authorities, for the same physical thing on one site — one pair is the substation, the other the on-site power plant. Both are required, and neither authorises the other: a decision on one does not oblige the other to follow. There is no order between them, which is why they carry a letter rather than an arrow — they can be filed and decided in either sequence, or at the same time. It matters because holding the provincial permit is not holding the municipal one, and a project can win one and lose the other. Check that the site plan filed with each shows the same footprint and that the conditions do not contradict, and reconcile them at pre-application rather than at decision.



A power plant needs both approvals

Where a project proposes on-site generation, the AUC approves the generating facility and the municipality still permits the site development around it. They are separate files on separate records, marked here by a shared pair letter on both cards. Neither one authorises the other.



Two approvals, one site

The municipality approves the building; the AUC approves the substation that powers it. Neither authorises the other, and both site plans must show the same footprint — reconcile them at pre-application, not at decision.



Occupancy is the real gate

Construction can finish while the power is still outstanding — an unfinished connection on the grid route, an uncommissioned plant or an unsecured fuel supply off it. Conditioning occupancy, rather than construction, on evidence of firm power is enforceable, within municipal jurisdiction, and prevents a stranded building.

 A map of the process, not legal advice. Confirm each requirement against the authority named before relying on it.